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From Followers to Founders: Influencer Made Products in Consumer Markets

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Abstract. What drives the success of influencer made products remains an open question as most existing influencer marketing research focuses on paid endorsements rather than influencers acting as product creators and owners. Building on prior work on influencer authenticity, congruence between influencer and product, engagement quality, and follower trust, this research will examine how influencer attributes such as authenticity, audience fit, and follower engagement interact with product level characteristics including product visibility in content and various other factors. Unlike earlier studies that evaluate campaign effectiveness or influencer selection, this project shifts the unit of analysis to influencer owned products, allowing engagement and trust to translate directly into market outcomes. By linking influencer content, engagement measures, and influencer persona, the study extends past research by showing when influencer social capital converts into sustainable product success rather than short term attention or hype.

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Key words: Influencer Marketing,

1. Introduction

1.1. Overview of influencer marketing

Influencer marketing is when a brand pays or collaborates with a social media creator to promote something to their followers in a way that feels personal or authentic. In brand influencer marketing the way to get an influencer to show off your product follows four simple steps:

1. A brand finds an influencer whose audience matches their target market
2. The influencer creates content featuring the product
3. Followers see the recommendation from someone they trust
4. Which leads to an increase in awareness, trust, and sales for the brand

Influencer marketing has been a topic of concern for marketers since the dark ages of marketing. However, as of 2012, Influencer marketing has become mainstream driven by the rise of image-focused social media platforms. It has been over a decade since then and influencer marketing has exploded and changed in many vast ways. Several research projects have been explored to detail how best to be an influencer and how best to use an influencer for your brand. There is even a break down into the type of influencer they are based on the number of followers they have.

1.2. Research gap

If there are so many projects on this topic you may be asking why is there yet another paper diving deep into the real of realism that is influencer marketing. I give you one simple question in return: Where the gap is in the research? The most notable gap in the various literature about influencer marketing is that little is known about what brings value to an influencer made product. For example, what about Mr.Beast or Logan Paul drives the success or failure of their products. Furthermore, what is it about Shaquille O'Neal that gives him the ability to slap his name or face on a product and it becomes a best seller.

1.3. Research question

The research question we will be studying in this paper is about influencer made products. Specifically, what about an influencer makes their product valuable in the eyes of the consumers? Could it be that the amount of followers or comments establish trust and credibility? or is their something else sprinkled on top, hidden to the naked eye?

2. Theoretical Background and Literature Review

2.1. Influencer Marketing in Prior Research

Prior research on influencer marketing has developed along several complementary streams, including authenticity and reputation dynamics, congruence mechanisms, consumer decision processes, comparative effectiveness of influencers versus celebrities, and technological and demographic moderators of influencer impact.

A first stream examines the dynamic trade-off between authenticity and monetization. The authors develop a dynamic model in which influencers choose an optimal level of authenticity that simultaneously affects current revenue and the growth rate of awareness. The model predicts that small influencers prioritize authenticity to accelerate follower growth, whereas large influencers optimally shift toward monetization once awareness reaches a sufficiently high level. This finding contrasts with traditional reputation models, which predict that larger actors are more protective

of their reputational capital. Extensions further examine celebrities, viral content dynamics, and follower turnover, demonstrating that platform characteristics and external visibility alter optimal endorsement strategies Nistor et al. (2025).

A second stream emphasizes psychological congruence mechanisms. Understanding Influencer Marketing: The Role of Congruence Between Influencers, Products and Consumers grounds influencer effectiveness in balance, cognitive dissonance, and congruity theories. The study highlights the triadic interaction among influencer–follower congruence, influencer–product congruence, and follower–product congruence. Empirical results show that higher congruence strengthens consumer attitudes toward sponsored products, which in turn increases purchase and recommendation intentions. This work clarifies the psychological pathway through which influencer campaigns generate persuasion Zak and Hasprova (2020), Belanche et al. (2021).

A third line of research focuses on influencers within the broader consumer decision-making process. This work systematizes existing knowledge regarding influencer typologies, trust factors, and product category effects. Survey evidence suggests that influencer impact varies substantially across product categories, with stronger influence observed in apparel, cosmetics, and services than in food or electronics. The study also documents that consumers place greater weight on perceived expertise than on attractiveness when evaluating influencer credibility Zak and Hasprova (2020).

Meta-analytic evidence further refines understanding of influencer effectiveness. Findings indicate that social media influencers are more persuasive than brand-only advertisements and are statistically comparable to celebrity endorsers, with perceived credibility acting as a key moderator Lee et al. (2024).

More recent research incorporates demographic heterogeneity, technological change, and advanced modeling techniques. Using mixed methods, including regression analysis and Fuzzy Cognitive Mapping, this work examines how authenticity, transparency, and engagement quality influence consumer trust and purchasing behavior across industries and demographic groups. Results indicate that influencer marketing effects are stronger among younger consumers and in fashion and beauty industries, while excessive promotional activity may induce ad fatigue. The study also integrates technological dimensions such as AI-driven personalization and virtual try-ons, highlighting the evolving digital ecosystem in which influencer marketing operates Migkos et al. (2025).

Taken together, prior research establishes that influencer effectiveness depends on dynamic authenticity management, psychological congruence, credibility perceptions, product category

characteristics, and platform-specific dynamics. However, the majority of this literature focuses on paid endorsements rather than influencer-created and owned products. As a result, the mechanisms through which influencer social capital translates into direct product ownership outcomes remain underexplored.

2.2. Observable Influencer Characteristics

There are numerous observable characteristics identified in prior research as important indicators of the value an influencer can bring to a brand. Observable characteristics refer to the visible cues consumers encounter when viewing a social media post. These include audience size (e.g., number of followers), engagement metrics (e.g., likes and comments), posting frequency, content style, and patterns of audience interaction Zak and Hasprova (2020),Migkos et al. (2025).

Because social media environments provide limited information and rapid consumption, consumers rely on these visible signals as heuristic cues when forming judgments about an influencer. Rather than conducting deep evaluations, consumers often use engagement metrics and presentation style to infer broader qualities such as credibility, expertise, and social approval. Importantly, these surface-level indicators shape deeper perceptions of the influencer, including whether the influencer is trustworthy, honest, and authentic. Thus, observable characteristics function as the foundation upon which more complex relational evaluations are formed Belanche et al. (2021), Lee et al. (2024).

2.3. Trust, Honesty, and Authenticity

Observable characteristics play a critical role in shaping consumer perceptions of both the influencer and the product being promoted. Beyond the content of the message itself, visible signals such as engagement metrics, audience size, and presentation style influence how consumers interpret the credibility of the promotion. For influencer-created products in particular, the influencer must persuade consumers that the product effectively fulfills a meaningful need and provides genuine value Belanche et al. (2021), Lee et al. (2024), Zak and Hasprova (2020).

Influencers often attempt to accomplish this by demonstrating product usage scenarios and describing how the product has improved their own lives. However, consumers do not rely solely on these claims. Instead, they evaluate underlying qualities of the influencer to determine whether the promotional message should be believed Migkos et al. (2025), Belanche et al. (2021), Nistor et al. (2025).

Specifically, consumers assess:

- **Trustworthiness:** The extent to which the influencer is perceived as reliable and dependable. Much like reviews the engagement on a post is important here. The number of Comments and likes can make or break a consumer's willingness to purchase Lee et al. (2024), Zak and Hasprova (2020), Migkos et al. (2025).
- **Honesty:** The degree to which the influencer appears truthful and transparent in their communication. This often comes across in the posts commentary wether written or spoken. The way the influencer depicts the product is important Migkos et al. (2025), Nistor et al. (2025).
- **Authenticity:** The extent to which the influencer presents themselves as genuine rather than purely commercial or promotional. The words the influencer uses to describe the product feel real and not another commercial Nistor et al. (2025), Migkos et al. (2025).

Together, these perceptions shape consumer responses to influencer-created products and influence purchase intentions.

3. Methodology

3.1. Likert Scale Measures

Given the limited research on influencer-created products (as opposed to influencer endorsements), this study adapts established influencer marketing constructs to the context of influencer-owned brands. Respondents evaluated a simulated social media post using Likert-scale measures.

Participants were shown a social media post featuring an influencer promoting their own product. Elements of the post varied across conditions, including engagement metrics (number of likes and comments) and caption tone (formal versus casual). After viewing the post, respondents indicated their level of agreement with a series of statements using seven-point Likert scales ranging from strongly disagree to strongly agree.

The Likert items were designed to measure the following constructs:

- **Purchase Intention:** The extent to which the respondent would consider trying or buying the featured product.
- **Perceived Honesty:** The degree to which the influencer is viewed as truthful and transparent in promoting the product.
- **Perceived Authenticity:** The extent to which the influencer appears genuine rather than purely promotional.
- **Perceived Credibility:** The level of trustworthiness and believability attributed to the influencer.

Engagement metrics (likes and comments) were manipulated to reflect realistic but varying levels of audience interaction. Caption language was also manipulated to reflect either a more formal product introduction or a more casual, conversational tone. These variations allow for examination of how presentation style and visible engagement influence consumer perceptions of influencer-created products.

3.2. Survey Measures

3.2.1. Demographic Information Demographic information was gathered as well. These variables were gathered to see the effect of varying demographic information on the mega influencers value. The demographic variables have been broken up into two different groups: Behavioral demographics and Socio-Demographics. The demographic variables are listed below:

- **Behavioral Demographics:**
  - **Platform Usage:** Social media platforms the respondent reports using (e.g., YouTube, Facebook, Instagram).
  - **Familiar Influencers:** A list of prominent influencers the respondent indicates being familiar with (e.g., MrBeast, Logan Paul, Stephen Curry).
  - **Frequency of Usage:** How often the respondent uses social media, ranging from daily to never.
  - **Purchased Influencer Products:** Whether the respondent has purchased a product because it was recommended or promoted by an influencer.
- **Socio-Demographics:**
  - **Education Level:** The highest level of education completed by the respondent.
  - **Race:** The racial identity self-reported by the respondent.
  - **Age:** The respondent's age, categorized into ten-year intervals.
  - **Gender:** The gender identity self-reported by the respondent.
  - **Employment Status:** The respondent's employment status within the past three months.
  - **Marital Status:** The respondent's current marital status.
  - **Income Level:** The respondent's self-reported income category.

3.3. Stimulus Design: Social Media Post

To examine how observable characteristics influence consumer perceptions, respondents were shown a simulated social media post in which an influencer promoted their own product. The post was designed to closely resemble a typical Instagram-style promotional upload in order to enhance realism and external validity.

Each post contained the following elements:

- A product image positioned at the top of the post
- The influencer's username and profile identifier
- Engagement metrics (number of likes and comments)
- A written caption describing the product

Two key elements of the post were experimentally varied across conditions: (1) engagement metrics (likes and comments), and (2) caption tone (formal versus casual language).

Engagement metrics were manipulated to reflect realistic but varying levels of audience interaction. Caption tone was adjusted to reflect either a structured, product-focused description (formal condition) or a conversational, personality-driven message (casual condition). To illustrate the experimental manipulation, representative examples of both caption conditions are presented below.

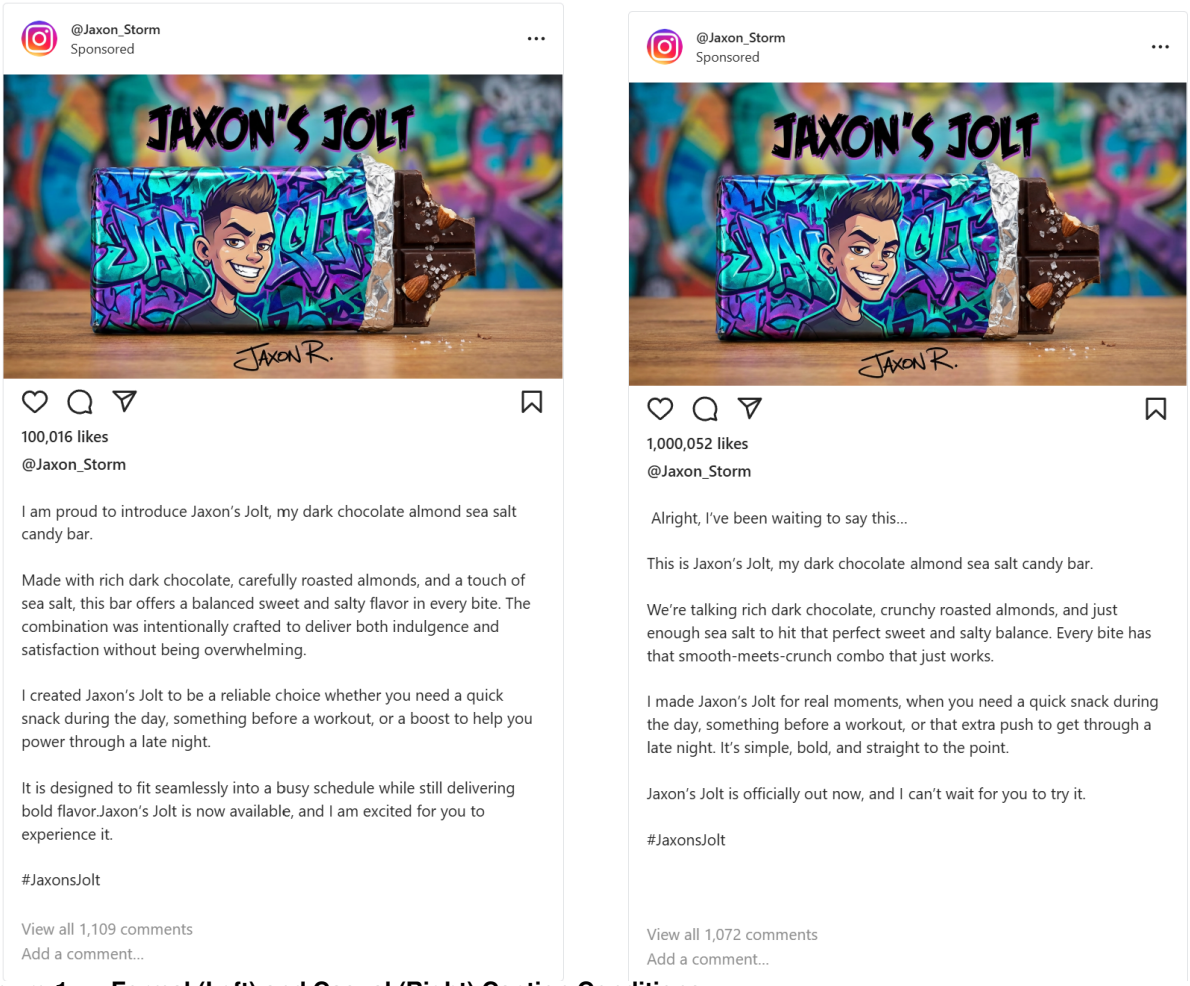

Figure 1 Formal (Left) and Casual (Right) Caption Conditions

Aside from caption tone and engagement metrics, all other elements of the post were held constant across conditions. The product image, influencer identity, layout, hashtags, and overall visual structure remained identical. This ensured that any differences in respondent evaluations could be attributed to the manipulated variables rather than unrelated visual differences.

After viewing the post, respondents evaluated the influencer and product using seven-point Likert scale measures assessing trustworthiness, honesty, authenticity, and purchase intention.

3.4. Mathematical Models

This subsection describes the theoretical frameworks and mathematical models used in the study. The models formalize the relationships between influencer authenticity, engagement, and consumer responses. Key equations and assumptions are presented to provide a clear understanding of the underlying dynamics.

3.5. Statistical and Analytical Methods

This subsection details the statistical and analytical techniques employed. Methods include regression analysis, hypothesis testing, and meta-analytic approaches where applicable. The section also outlines how these methods were used to test research hypotheses and interpret the data.

4. Results

4.1. Significant positive effects

4.2. Significant negative effects

4.3. Non-significant effects

5. Discussion

5.1. Theoretical Contributions

5.2. Managerial Implications

5.3. Limitations

One of the largest and most prominent limitation reflected in this project is that we only ran the analysis on chocolate bars. To improve and continue the research would mean to add new products and determine the cross category effects on the market. What is the difference between a fashion influencer who makes clothes and accessories and a snack influencer who makes a variety of snacks for the market?

6. Conclusion

The From Followers to Founders project has discovered....(hopefully something cool)

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